A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR SENIOR PROFESSIONALS

I just lost my *(corporate leadership)* job. What now?

What to do — and what never to do — when your corporate role disappears. A candid, human guide for senior professionals navigating one of life's most disorienting transitions.

Ric Vicari, March 2026

3 Parts | 8 Chapters | Emotional Intelligence | Strategic Advice

To Tatiana, always by my side, in joy and in sorrow.

Why this book

I went through this process twice. The first time, I made almost every mistake described in these pages. I moved too fast without clarity. I treated my network as a single undifferentiated resource. I let radio silence convince me that opportunities had died when they had not. I negotiated at the wrong moment, in the wrong way. I came out the other side with a new role, but the process was longer, harder, and more demoralising than it needed to be.

The second time, it found me prepared. I had developed a method, not from a book, but from the first experience and from years spent helping friends and colleagues navigate the same transition. I refined it with each person I discussed their process with. Some found roles quickly. Some took longer. But all of them told me that having a structure, a way of thinking about the process rather than simply reacting to it, made the difference between feeling in control and feeling at the mercy of events.

Some asked me to put what we discussed in writing. So here I am.

This book does not have the ambition to be the perfect guide for all seasons. Other people have developed methods that work better for them, and those are worth following too. What I can offer is a specific set of battle-tested approaches from someone who has been exactly where you are now, more than once, and who came out the other side with a clear view of what helped and what did not.

See this as one of many sources of shared experience. Its only ambition is to make you feel a little less alone in this, today, that is not a good day, and give you purpose and focus to get up and move in the most efficient direction to be employed again as soon as possible.

We all know that hope is not a strategy, but to keep an optimistic view that a relevant job for you exists out there, helps more than you think to get there. All the best in your job search.

> *"Whoever deserves you will find you. Do the work to make sure they can."*

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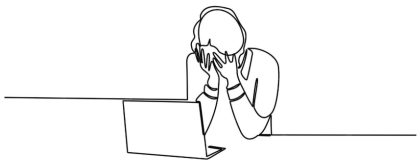
PART ONE

Orientation

The first days, the right mindset, and the plan that holds everything together.



CHAPTER ONE

I just lost my *(corporate leadership)* job. What now?

The first hours after the news. What you are feeling is real — and what you do next matters more than you think.

It might have come as a complete shock. Or perhaps there were signs — a restructuring quietly underway, a relationship with your manager that had cooled, a reorg that seemed to leave your function oddly exposed, a strategy meeting you were strangely not invited to attend.

Either way, the moment it becomes real — the call, the meeting, the carefully worded email — something shifts. The ground you have been standing on turns out to have been less solid than you thought.

Senior leaders are not immune to this feeling. In fact, the more senior you are, the more disorienting the experience can be. Your identity, your calendar, your daily purpose, your status — all of it has been bound up in that role for years. Losing the role does not just mean losing income. It can feel like losing yourself.

> *"The instinct is to act immediately. The wisdom is to pause long enough to act well."*

This book is not a therapy guide, though it will acknowledge the emotional reality of what you are going through. It is, above all, a practical guide — written for senior professionals in the tech world and beyond — about how to navigate the next three to four months without making the mistakes that delay or derail what is, for most people in your position, an inevitable recovery.

The uncomfortable truth is this: you are not in control of how quickly the right opportunity arrives. You cannot manufacture a job offer. You cannot speed up a hiring committee. What you can do is protect your candidacy, manage your energy, and avoid the errors that are entirely within your control to prevent. That is what this book is about.

The question everyone will ask: why?

You will be asked this question more times than you expect, and by more people than you are ready for. Colleagues, friends, recruiters, board members, hiring managers, your children. Everyone wants to understand what happened. Your answer to this question is one of the most important things you will prepare — because how you tell this story will shape how people see you, and how you see yourself.

The answer needs to be three things simultaneously: sharp, transparent, and calibrated to your audience. It should never be a rant. It should never be an excuse. And it should never be a performance of false peace you have not actually made.

TO A CEO OR BOARD MEMBER	TO YOUR FAMILY	TO YOURSELF
Culture misalignment, shifting strategic priorities, investor pressure, internal politics. Keep it factual. Do not editorialize.	Companies make business decisions. I may not have agreed with this one. We move on, and I believe something better is ahead.	There are always two sides. Be honest about what you could have done differently. Then let it go.

To a senior executive or potential employer, the answer should be clean and forward-looking. Companies restructure. Strategies change. Investors apply pressure that reshapes priorities. Internal politics are real. All of these are legitimate explanations — and the best candidates offer them without bitterness, without excessive detail, and without making the listener feel they are being recruited as a sympathiser. One sentence on what happened. One sentence on what you learned. One sentence on where you are going.

To your family — and especially to your children — the language should be honest but calm. Companies make business decisions. You may privately believe the decision was wrong or unfair. That is allowed. But the energy you spend on grievance is energy you cannot spend on recovery. Say it clearly: this is not the end of the story. We move forward.

And to yourself — the most important audience of all — be genuinely vulnerable. There are always two sides to every professional ending. What did you see coming and not address? Where did the relationship break down, and what was your part in it? What would you do differently? Do not hold a grudge. Grudges are extraordinarily expensive. The person who wronged you, the decision that felt unjust — they are not thinking about it. You cannot afford to be the only one still carrying it.

> *"Don't hold a grudge. It is wasted energy. Whoever deserves you will find you."*

Finally, remember: your answer to the why question is not just about managing perceptions. It is about how you make sense of what happened. The professionals who navigate this transition best are those who can tell a coherent story — one that acknowledges what went wrong, demonstrates what they learned, and points clearly toward what comes next. That story begins here.

DO

- Give yourself 24 hours before making any moves
- Call one trusted confidant — not ten people
- Read your severance agreement carefully before signing
- Prepare your why answer for different audiences
- Be genuinely vulnerable with yourself about what you learned

DON'T

- Post on LinkedIn in the first 48 hours
- Make any major financial decisions this week
- Say anything negative about the company — to anyone
- Sign anything under time pressure without legal review
- Carry a grudge. The energy cost is too high.

REFLECTION

Write your why answer in three versions: one for a CEO, one for your family, one for yourself. Which version is hardest to write honestly?

CHAPTER TWO

Accept it: this will take 3-4 months. Plan for it.

The single most important thing you can do right now is set a realistic expectation — with yourself and with your family.

The most common mistake senior professionals make in the first week is underestimating the timeline. They assume their seniority, their network, their track record will compress what is — for everyone — a structurally long process. It will not. At VP, SVP or CXO-level in the technology sector, a well-run search typically takes three to six months from the moment you start actively looking to the moment you accept an offer. Sometimes less. Often more.

This is not pessimism. It is arithmetic. Hiring committees at senior level move slowly. Legal approvals, board sign-offs, and headcount freezes all create friction. Headhunters work multiple mandates simultaneously. Decisions that should take a week take three. Planning for this reality is not defeatism — it is the foundation on which everything else in this book rests.

> *"Plan for four months. If it happens in two, you will be pleasantly surprised. If it takes five or six, you will not be destroyed."*

Day 1	Month 1	Month 2	Month 3-4
Start	Clarity & outreach	Active pipeline	Offer & close

Before thinking about the search process, it is key to get ready for this long journey, financially, emotionally and physically. Let's look at each aspect in turn.

Financially

The moment you know the timeline, you can build a bridge to it. Calculate your monthly outgoings honestly — mortgage or rent, school fees if applicable, household costs, the subscriptions you actually use. Then look at your runway: severance, savings, any income your partner brings in. You are not trying to panic — you are trying to achieve clarity. A budget is not a constraint; it is a decision-making tool. It tells you how much time you actually have, which in turn tells you how much urgency is real and how much is manufactured by anxiety.

Resist the urge to immediately monetise your time through consulting or interim work unless you genuinely want that path. Short-term income can feel reassuring but can muddy your market positioning and dilute the focus you need for a clean, well-targeted search.

And if keeping up with the Joneses has been your priority, press the pause button. This is crisis management.

Emotionally — what to tell your family, and when

Tell your partner immediately and fully. Secrets of this magnitude corrode trust faster than bad news ever could. Frame the situation honestly: you have lost a role, you have a clear plan, it will take time, and you will get through it together. Your children need age-appropriate truth, not a performance of normality they can already see through. A quiet, confident acknowledgement — Dad (or Mum) is between jobs and looking for something great — does far less damage than the alternative.

Your wider family and social circle can wait. There is no upside to broadcasting before you are ready. When you are, you will have a story — not an emergency.

Physically

Structure is not optional. When the calendar empties, the body and mind follow. Build a daily routine before you need one. Exercise regularly — not to fill time, but because the neurochemical benefits are the single most evidence-backed intervention for the anxiety and low-grade depression that accompany job loss at any level. Your physical state is directly connected to how you present in interviews, on calls, in the room. This is competitive advantage, not a lifestyle tip.

FINANCIALLY	EMOTIONALLY	PHYSICALLY
Calculate your real runway. Clarity beats anxiety every time.	Tell your partner everything, immediately. Everyone else can wait.	Build your routine before you need it. Structure is competitive advantage.

They will tell you: take advantage of the downtime...

People will tell you this is a great opportunity to travel, recharge, spend time with the kids, read the books you have been meaning to read. They are not wrong — but they are not quite right either. Rest and recovery are real and necessary. But the professionals who emerge from this period strongest are those who treat downtime as recovery within the search, not as a reason to delay starting it. Take the holiday if you need to. Just do not take it instead of beginning.

... but start the process immediately

The search does not begin the day you feel ready. It begins the day you lose the role. Your market positioning starts accruing the moment news travels — and in senior tech circles, it travels fast. You do not need to be polished to start. You need to be moving. The first stage — reflection, research, and clarity — is internal work that can begin immediately, even while you are still processing the news.

You are not in control of acceleration — but you can make mistakes that delay

This point is worth sitting with. You will be tempted to believe that you can manufacture momentum — by sending more messages, following up more aggressively, widening your search to roles you would never actually take. None of this helps. Most of it hurts. The focus of this book is not on how to go faster. It is on how to avoid going slower through the behaviours and errors that are entirely within your control.

> *"You cannot make the offer come faster. You can absolutely make it come later."*

You have got to believe it: it is only a matter of time

For most senior professionals with a genuine track record, meaningful network, and a focused search strategy, this statement is not motivational rhetoric — it is statistically accurate. The vast majority find an equivalent or better role within six months. The variable is not whether it happens. The variable is how much you undermine the process while waiting for it to happen.

The advantage if you are in enterprise solution selling

If your background is in enterprise solution selling — selling complex products to complex buying centres, navigating multi-stakeholder decision-making processes, managing long cycles where the deal can go quiet for weeks before suddenly accelerating — you have a profound and often underappreciated advantage in this process.

Here is the reframe: this time, the product is you.

Everything you know about complex sales applies directly. You know that the buying cycle is long and non-linear. You know that silence is not rejection — it is process. You know that there are multiple stakeholders with different priorities, different objections, and different timelines, and that the deal rarely closes through a single champion alone. You know how to build a pipeline, how to qualify opportunities, how to manage a relationship through a long evaluation cycle without becoming either invisible or irritating. You know how to present value compellingly without overselling, and how to read a room to understand where real resistance lies.

Apply all of it. Your target companies are your accounts. Hiring managers are your economic buyers. HR is your procurement team — necessary, but rarely the decision-maker. Your network contacts are your internal champions, the people who can open doors and shape perception before you ever reach a formal process. Your CV and your elevator pitch are your deck. Your interviews are your demos.

The principles are identical. The cycle length is similar. The need for patience, discipline, and pipeline management is the same. The professional who treats a job search like a sales campaign — systematic, targeted, relationship-led, resilient to slow periods — will almost always outperform the one who treats it like a series of applications.

> *"You have spent years learning how to close complex deals. This is one more. The product is you — and you know it better than any product you have ever sold."*

The advice for everyone else

If your background is not in sales, the same principles apply — but they need translation. A job search at senior level is not a passive process. It is not about uploading your CV to a portal and waiting. It is an active, outbound campaign in which you are simultaneously the product, the salesperson, and the account manager.

That means: know what you are selling (your skills, your track record, your specific value proposition). Know who you are selling to (a defined list of target employers, not a vague category). Know how to have the conversation (an elevator pitch that is specific, confident, and adapted to your audience). And know how to manage the pipeline (which conversations are warm, which are stalled, which need a next step).

The market at senior level rewards specificity above almost everything else. A broad search casts a wide net and catches very little. A focused search — targeted, relationship-led, consistently executed — is what actually produces offers. We cover exactly how to build this in Stage 1.

Think of it like training for a marathon

Here is an analogy that helps if you do not come from a sales background — and that resonates equally if you do. Think about what it takes to run a marathon, or to complete an Ironman. Not just to finish — to compete.

You did not arrive at your current professional level by accident. Years of accumulated experience, setbacks absorbed, skills sharpened, judgment earned — all of it represents training. The same dedication that gets an athlete to the start line of an Ironman is what got you to the level you are at now. You have done the work. You have the fitness. This race is not beyond you.

Now consider what a marathon actually demands of the athlete who knows their own body. They understand their average pace and what it means at each stage of the course. They know how their legs feel at kilometre eight, at kilometre twenty, at kilometre thirty-five. They know the wall is coming and roughly when. They know when to take water, when to take a gel, when to push, and when to conserve. They are not surprised by the difficulty of the final ten kilometres — they planned for it. It is not over until it is over.

A job search works exactly the same way. The early weeks feel energising — new conversations, sharp pitch, optimism. The middle weeks can feel like a plateau. Weeks seven to ten are often the hardest: the initial pipeline has not yet converted, the novelty has worn off, and the silence can feel like failure. This is the equivalent of kilometre thirty in a marathon. It is not the end. It is the point at which preparation, structure, and self-knowledge determine who finishes well.

Know your own pace. Know that the process has stages, and that each stage demands something different from you. Know that the discomfort at stage three of four is not a sign that something has gone wrong — it is a sign that you are in the race. Stay fuelled: keep your routines, your

connections, your sense of forward motion. The finish line is fixed. Your job is to get there in good shape.

> *"You trained for years to get to this level. This is one more race. You know how to run it. And unlike the marathon, you already know you will finish."*

It is a numbers game

Here is a number that most people in this situation do not know, and that almost everyone finds uncomfortable when they first hear it: expect to speak with around 60 companies to generate approximately 8 active processes, which will result in roughly 3 job offers. Read that again. Sixty conversations. Eight real processes. Three offers.

This is not a reason for despair. It is a reason for discipline. The search is a funnel — and like every funnel, the quality of what comes out depends entirely on the quality of what goes in. If you approach 60 companies indiscriminately, the eight processes you generate will be weak and the offers, if they come, will be the wrong ones. If you approach 60 companies with precision — selected because they match your seniority, your domain knowledge, and your natural career trajectory — those eight processes will be serious conversations, and those three offers will be real choices.

~60	~8	~3
COMPANIES	PROCESSES	OFFERS
conversations initiated	active hiring conversations	real decisions to make

The most important filter is seniority match. Nobody will give you a role you are overqualified for on paper, and nobody will give you a role you are not yet qualified for in reality. The market is, in this sense, efficient. Targeting roles that are genuinely beneath you is not a safe fallback strategy — it is a waste of pipeline. Hiring managers who see a candidate chasing junior roles become concerned, not reassured. They wonder what is wrong. And if by chance they do hire you, you will be gone the moment something better emerges — which makes you a flight risk, and which they know before you do.

The same logic applies at the top end. Stretching your target list toward roles that require ten years more experience, a deeper technical background, or a different commercial track record than you possess is not ambition — it is noise. It dilutes your credibility with the contacts who facilitate those introductions, and it produces conversations that go nowhere and consume time you cannot afford to waste.

Aim true. Not modestly — but honestly. The sweet spot is roles where you are genuinely qualified, where your domain knowledge is relevant, and where the step up or across is credible given where you have been. That is not a small target. For a senior professional with a real track record, it is a large and rich one. Sixty companies is achievable. The discipline is in choosing the right sixty.

> *"Aim true. Not modestly — but honestly. The right sixty companies will produce better results than two hundred wrong ones."*

DO

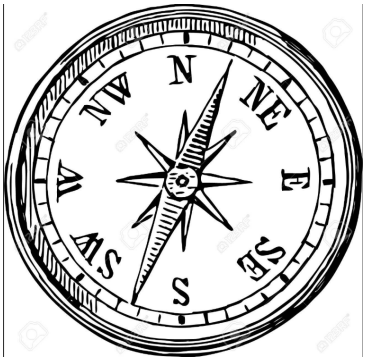
- Accept 3-4 months as the baseline — plan around it
- Tell your — plan around it
- Tell your partner fully and immediately
- Build and maintain a daily physical routine
- Start the clarity process from day one
- If you are in sales — run this like a sales campaign

DON'T

- Assume your seniority compresses the timeline
- Take interim work reflexively to feel busy
- Widen your search before clarifying your target
- Use recharging as a reason not to start
- Let anxiety push you into volume over quality

REFLECTION

Write down your real monthly outgoings and your real runway. Not approximately — exactly. What does that number tell you about how much urgency is real, and how much is anxiety?



CHAPTER THREE

The process in four stages

A map of the search — so you always know where you are, and what the next move is.

A senior job search is not a single action. It is a process — sequential in structure but iterative in practice, with distinct stages that demand different mindsets, different tools, and different measures of progress. The most disorienting thing about the experience is precisely this: that working hard on the search looks entirely different at week two than it does at week eight.

What follows is a map. Not a guarantee — the timeline varies, stages overlap, and setbacks happen — but a structure that allows you to locate yourself within the process at any given moment. When you know what stage you are in, you know what success looks like today. That clarity is protective.

> *"The search feels chaotic because you cannot see the shape of it. This is the shape of it."*

01

Reflection, research and clarity

The internal work. Who you are, what you offer, where you are going — and to whom. You cannot run an effective outbound search without this foundation.

02

Outbound search — the five groups

Systematic, prioritised outreach. Not a broadcast — a campaign. Every contact falls into one of five categories, each requiring a different approach.

03

Radio silence — how to hold steady

The hardest part. Periods of no response are structural, not personal. The behaviours you exhibit here often determine whether an opportunity survives.

04

Managing the preferred candidate moment

When one or more companies identify you as their top choice, a new set of risks emerges. Most people mishandle this stage. You do not have to.

Clarity	Outbound	Hold steady	Close
Weeks 1-3	Weeks 3-10	Ongoing	Weeks 10-16

Stages 1 and 2 are broadly sequential — you build clarity before you run outreach, because unfocused outreach is worse than no outreach. Stages 3 and 4 are concurrent with Stage 2 — radio silence begins the moment your first message lands, and the preferred candidate moment can arrive at any point from week four onwards. The map is linear; the experience is not. That is normal.

DO

- Know which stage you are in — and act accordingly
- Treat the search as a professional campaign, not a series of applications
- Keep detailed notes on every conversation and contact
- Review and update your target list weekly
- Celebrate small progress — an introduction, a first call, a referral

DON'T

- Jump to Stage 2 before Stage 1 is solid
- Treat all contacts as interchangeable — they are not
- Let the search go dark for more than a week
- Measure progress in applications sent, not quality conversations had
- Conflate activity with momentum

REFLECTION

Which stage are you in right now? Are you behaving as that stage requires — or as a previous stage did?

PART TWO

The process

Four stages. One direction. No shortcuts.

CHAPTER FOUR

Stage 1 — Reflection, research and clarity

You cannot sell what you have not defined. The clarity stage is not preparation — it is the work.

Most people skip this stage. They spend a day or two updating their CV, reach out to a handful of contacts, and consider themselves in the market. They are not. They are in motion without direction — which is arguably worse than standing still, because it burns through the goodwill of their network before they know what they are actually asking for.

The clarity stage is uncomfortable precisely because it requires you to make choices. Choices about what you want. Choices about what you are willing to trade off. Choices about which version of your professional self you are going to put forward. Those choices feel limiting — but they are the opposite. A focused candidate is a compelling candidate. A vague candidate is forgettable.

Be clear about your transferable skills and your value

Start with the evidence, not the aspiration. Look at the last three to five years of your career and identify the outcomes you produced — not the responsibilities you held, but the things that actually changed because you were there. Revenue grown. Deals closed. Products shipped. Teams built. Markets entered. Problems solved that others had failed to solve.

Now ask: which of these outcomes would another organisation pay for? That intersection — what you have demonstrably done, and what the market values — is your transferable value proposition. Write it down in plain language. If you cannot explain it in two sentences, it is not yet clear enough.

Value is a relative concept

Your value is not fixed — it is relative to the type of organisation you are speaking with. The same track record, skills, and seniority can be read in completely different ways depending on the

company's size, stage, and competitive position. Understanding this is not an exercise in modesty. It is a strategic necessity that shapes both where you target and how you pitch.

Consider a senior executive who has spent fifteen years at an automotive OEM. That person's network, domain knowledge, and understanding of complex buying cycles is extremely valuable — but read very differently by a competing OEM, by a large technology vendor selling into automotive, and by an early-stage startup. The matrix below makes the contrast visible.

	Automotive OEM	Large tech vendor	Startup / scaleup
Domain knowledge	Extremely high — directly transferable	High — OEM buying cycles are the product they sell into	Moderate — relevant but not the main value driver
Network value	High — peers, suppliers, regulators	Very high — exactly the access the vendor needs	Lower — OEM network is less relevant at early stage
Perceived risk	Culture fit; may be seen as competitor-trained	Low — sector knowledge is a clear advantage	High — startup experience gap is the core concern
What they worry about	Loyalty conflicts; different internal politics	Can they sell beyond the sector they came from?	Will they leave when a large-company offer arrives?
Pitch emphasis	Cultural alignment + specific competitive insight	Customer access + sector credibility + sales experience	Adaptability + bias for action + commercial results proof

The practical implication: tailor your pitch to the type of organisation, not just the role. A competing OEM wants evidence of cultural alignment and specific competitive insight. A large tech vendor wants your sector access and relationships. A startup wants reassurance that you can operate without a large-company infrastructure, that you are comfortable with ambiguity, and that you will not leave the moment a bigger title arrives. Address these concerns proactively — they will surface.

Be clear and focused about your ideal next step

You need clarity on three dimensions: role, vertical, and geography. Not ranges — specifics. Not VP of something commercial in tech somewhere in Europe — but VP of Business Development at a Series C SaaS company in the UK or Germany, ideally in fintech or connected infrastructure.

This level of specificity feels uncomfortable because it seems to narrow your options. It does not. It sharpens your message, which makes every conversation more productive, every introduction more precise, and every interaction more likely to generate a useful next step. You can always expand later. You cannot recover from six weeks of unfocused outreach.

ROLE CLARITY
What do you want to do and at what level? Specific title, remit, seniority — not a range.

VERTICAL CLARITY
Which sectors or company types are you targeting, and why? You need a credible specific answer.

GEOGRAPHY
Where are you willing to work? Remote, hybrid, travel — be honest with yourself and with them.

COMPANY SIZE
Startup, scaleup, mid-market, enterprise, multinational — each has different culture and pace. Know which suits you.

SOLUTION DOMAIN
What type of product or service? Your industry knowledge combined with your solution expertise defines where your pitch is strongest.

Company size matters more than most candidates acknowledge. The skills, pace, and tolerance for ambiguity required in a 30-person startup are meaningfully different from those in a 30,000-person multinational. Neither is better — but pretending you are equally suited to both makes your pitch feel unconvincing. Be honest about where you have operated and thrived, and — if you are making a deliberate move across the size spectrum — be ready to explain concretely why and how you will adapt.

Solution domain — the specific type of product, service, or technology you have worked with — is where your pitch becomes most distinctive. A senior executive with a background in complex IoT connectivity solutions sold to automotive OEMs has a very specific combination of industry knowledge and solution expertise. That combination is rare and valuable — but only to organisations that need exactly that. Rather than generalising it away ("I have worked in technology"), double down on it. The narrower and more specific your domain definition, the more precisely it points to the organisations where you are not just a good candidate — but the obvious one.

Build a target list of prospective employers

This is one of the most underrated activities in a senior job search. Most people wait for opportunities to come to them — via job boards, headhunters, or word of mouth. The strongest candidates also generate their own pipeline by identifying companies they want to work for before those companies are publicly hiring.

Build a list of 50-60 target organisations. Use your sector knowledge, your network, your reading of the market. For each one, note why you think you could add value, who the relevant hiring decision-maker is likely to be, and whether you have any connection into the company. This list becomes the foundation of your outbound search in Stage 2.

Identify specific names of hiring managers

A target list of companies is not enough. You need names. The person who would hire you is not HR — it is the executive who would be your manager, your peer, or your sponsor. Use LinkedIn, company websites, your network, and press coverage to identify these individuals by name. When you ask for an introduction, you want to be able to say: I am looking to connect with the Chief Revenue Officer at Company X — do you know them? Not: do you know anyone at Company X?

Have your elevator pitch ready — long and short

You need two versions. The short version — thirty seconds, the length of an introduction at an event or the opening of a networking call — should cover who you are, what you have done, and what you are looking for. Specifically. The long version — three to five minutes, for a first exploratory conversation — adds the evidence: the outcomes, the sectors, the scale, the specific value you bring.

Both versions should be adapted for your audience. Speaking to a CEO requires a different emphasis than speaking to a headhunter. Speaking to a peer contact requires a different register than speaking to a formal interviewer. The content is consistent; the framing shifts.

Rehearse

This is the step everyone knows they should do and almost no one does adequately. Rehearse your pitch out loud, not in your head. Record yourself. Ask a trusted friend or colleague to listen and give feedback. Do a mock interview. The gap between what you think you sound like and what you actually sound like is almost always larger than you expect — and it narrows significantly with practice.

Rehearsal also builds the confidence that comes from familiarity. When you have said your pitch fifty times, you stop thinking about the words and start thinking about the person in front of you. That shift — from self-focused to other-focused — is what separates a good pitch from a great one.

> *"A focused candidate is a compelling one. A vague candidate is a forgettable one."*

DO

- Identify transferable outcomes — not just responsibilities
- Define solution domain, company size, role, vertical, and geography specifically
- Build a named list of 30-50 target companies
- Identify the specific hiring managers by name
- Rehearse your pitch out loud, on camera, with feedback

DON'T

- Start outreach before your clarity work is done
- Describe yourself in broad, generic terms
- Send the same message to every contact
- Rely on headhunters and job boards as your primary channel
- Skip rehearsal because you think you will wing it well

REFLECTION

Write your two-sentence value proposition. Then ask someone who knows your work well whether it matches what they would say about you.

Start a detailed journal

Buy a notebook. Open a spreadsheet. Start a notes file. It does not matter which — what matters is that you begin keeping a meticulous record of everything that happens in this search, from the day it starts to the day it ends.

Log every conversation: who you spoke with, what was said, what they asked, what you promised, what the agreed next step was. Log every outreach: what you sent, to whom, on what date, and what response came back. Log every decision you made and why. Summarise calls while they are still fresh — a paragraph is enough. This is your search CRM, and it is one of the most powerful tools available to you.

But go further than formal interactions. Note a profile view on LinkedIn from someone relevant at a target company. Note a like or a comment on a post you published. Note a text message from a former colleague checking in. Note a job posting that appeared at a company you had already approached. These small signals are not noise — they are data. And learning to distinguish three types of signal is one of the most important analytical skills of the search.

UNSOLICITED CONTACT

A very powerful signal

Profile views, unprompted messages, likes from relevant decision-makers, a recruiter reaching out without prior contact. These events happen independently of your outreach. They indicate that someone is actively looking — and that you appeared in that search. Record them separately. They carry far more weight than any response to something you initiated.

RESPONSES TO YOUR OUTREACH

Expected, but still valuable

Replies to your messages, callbacks from headhunters you contacted, meeting requests following your introductions. These confirm that your outreach is landing. Track them carefully — but distinguish them clearly from unsolicited signals, which mean something qualitatively different.

NO RESPONSE

Data, not rejection

Messages that generate no reply, meeting requests that are ignored, follow-ups that disappear. Do not read these as rejection. Read them as a pattern. Which types of message go unanswered? Which contacts never respond? Which asks are consistently met with silence? The pattern tells you something important about your approach — not about your worth.

Practical advice. At the end of every week go through the list of opportunities and rank them in order of maturity. Be brutally honest and strike out the ones that should be qualified out based on either negative feedback or lack of any feedback over a sustained period. Keep the list always clean.

At times, the small number of opportunities will cause concern. However, over time, you will thank yourself for being able to trust this data source.

CHAPTER FIVE

Stage 2 — Outbound search: the five groups

Not everyone in your network can help you in the same way. The mistake is treating them as if they can.

When people think about using their network in a job search, they typically imagine a sequence of coffees and calls with people they know, hoping that something useful will emerge. This is not a strategy. It is a social activity with the ambient hope of professional benefit.

A structured outbound search starts by recognising that your contacts fall into fundamentally different categories — and that each category requires a different approach, a different ask, and a different investment of your time and theirs. Mapping your network to these five groups is one of the highest-value things you will do in Stage 2.

> *"Your network is not a single resource. It is five different ones. Use each one accordingly."*

Group	How to approach them
Group 1 **People who can give you advice**	Talk to them early. They help you sharpen your story, stress-test your target list, and prepare for conversations with the other four groups. Do not ask them for introductions they cannot credibly make — it wastes their goodwill and produces weak referrals.
Group 2 **People who can make an introduction**	These contacts are connectors. They may not be able to hire you or advise you — but they know someone who can. For these conversations to produce results, you must be completely clear about who you want to meet. 'Someone in fintech' produces nothing. 'The CRO at Volt or a comparable Series B payments company' produces a call.

Group 3 **People who can potentially give you a job**	This is your highest-priority group. Treat these relationships with care. Do not open with the ask — open with genuine curiosity about their business, their challenges, their direction. The ask follows naturally from a conversation in which you have demonstrated relevance. Approach them as a peer, not as a supplicant.
Group 4 **People who can offer career progression**	These are contacts at companies or in roles that represent not just your next step but a meaningful step up — a larger remit, a more strategic platform, a bigger market. They require your most polished pitch and your clearest articulation of how you specifically add value to their specific situation.
Group 5 **Headhunters**	Headhunters work for companies, not candidates. They are useful when a company has engaged them for a specific mandate — which means they are relevant for a relatively small proportion of senior roles at any given time. Register with the right ones for your sector, keep them informed of your situation, and treat them as one channel among several — not your primary one.

A note on sequencing: start with Groups 1 and 2, where the pressure is lower and the conversations help you prepare. Move to Groups 3 and 4 once your pitch is sharp, your story is clear, and you have done enough preparatory conversations to be genuinely compelling. Approach headhunters early — not because they will find your next role, but because mandates sometimes move quickly and you want to already be on their radar.

Track every conversation. Note what was discussed, what was promised, what the next step is, and when you should follow up. This is exactly the discipline introduced in the journalling section — and the journal you started in Stage 1 is the same tool you are using here. A job search without a CRM — even a simple spreadsheet or notebook — is a job search that loses momentum through leakage. One missed follow-up with a Group 3 contact can cost you an opportunity that was closer than you knew.

> *"The ask must match the group. Asking Group 1 for a job is awkward. Asking Group 3 for generic advice is a missed opportunity."*

DO

- Map your contacts to the five groups before reaching out
- Be specific about who you want to meet — not vaguely curious
- Approach Group 3 and 4 contacts as a peer, with prepared relevance
- Track every conversation with a next step and a follow-up date
- Register with the right headhunters for your sector early

DON'T

- Treat your network as one undifferentiated resource
- Ask people to help without telling them specifically how
- Open a Group 3 conversation with the ask before building context
- Rely on headhunters as your primary or only channel
- Let conversations go without a clear next step

REFLECTION

Map your top 20 contacts to the five groups right now. Are you spending most of your time with Group 1 when you should be in Group 3?

CHAPTER SIX

Stage 3 — Radio silence: how not to let desperation take over

It will go quiet. This is normal. What you do in the silence is what determines whether the opportunity survives.

Every senior job search has periods of silence. A conversation that seemed to be building momentum suddenly stops producing responses. A company that was enthusiastic goes quiet for two weeks. A headhunter you spoke with three times stops returning calls. A contact who promised to introduce you to someone has not followed through.

These silences feel personal. They feel like rejection, or loss of interest, or evidence that something went wrong in the last conversation. In the vast majority of cases, they are none of these things. They are process. Hiring committees reschedule. Decision-makers travel. Budget conversations restart. Internal priorities shift for reasons that have nothing to do with you.

The problem is not the silence. The problem is what the silence does to your behaviour — and how that behaviour, in turn, affects your candidacy.

> *"Silence is not rejection. It is the buying cycle doing what buying cycles do."*

What desperation looks like from the other side

When candidates become anxious in a slow period, they tend to do one or more of the following: they follow up too frequently, they lower their bar and widen their search indiscriminately, they say yes to exploratory conversations they should have politely declined, they become less selective about the companies and roles they discuss — signalling to the market that they are available rather than exceptional.

Each of these behaviours is understandable. Each of them damages your candidacy in ways that are difficult to recover from. A candidate who follows up three times in two weeks signals anxiety. A candidate who suddenly pivots to roles they previously said they were not interested in signals instability. A candidate who says yes to everything signals they have nothing better to do.

The hiring managers and headhunters who are watching — and they are always watching, even when they appear to be silent — read these signals clearly. Seniority and availability are inversely correlated in most people's minds. The candidate who appears to have options, even during a quiet period, is more attractive than the one who appears to be waiting.

How to hold steady

The antidote to desperation is structure, not willpower. Build your week around activities that keep the search moving without requiring immediate response from others. Reach out to new contacts in Group 1 and Group 2. Refine your target list. Read the news from your target sectors and identify conversation starters. Update your pitch based on feedback you have received. Do the physical and intellectual maintenance that keeps you sharp.

Follow up — but once, after a reasonable interval, and with something of value to add. Do not send a message that says only: checking in — just wanted to stay on your radar. Send something that says: I came across this piece on the topic we discussed — thought it might be relevant. Or: I had a great conversation with your former colleague last week, which prompted me to think about your situation. A follow-up that adds value is almost always welcome. A follow-up that only signals anxiety rarely is.

Maintain your own pipeline of conversations, so that no single opportunity carries all the weight. When five conversations are in motion, the silence from one of them is annoying. When only one conversation is in motion, the silence from it is devastating. Density in the pipeline is the most effective antidote to the emotional volatility of the silent period.

> *"The candidate who appears to have options is more attractive than the one who appears to be waiting. Manage the perception — and manage yourself."*

The journal: your most underrated tool

Silence in response to your outreach is not rejection. It is information. The question to ask is not: why did they not reply to me? The question is: what pattern am I seeing across all the messages that generated no response?

Often the pattern is obvious once you look for it. You asked someone in Group 1 — an advice-giver — for a job, which is not theirs to give and places them in an awkward position. You asked someone in Group 2 — an introducer — to open a door you had not yet clearly described, leaving them with nothing specific to say on your behalf. You sent a generic message to a hiring manager at a company you had not researched. You followed up too quickly after an introduction, before the connection had time to land. None of these is a verdict on you. Each is a correctable error in approach.

Use the journal to audit your no-response column every two weeks. Sort your outreach by type of ask, by group, by format. Ask: what generated movement, and what generated nothing? Adjust. A search that does not learn from its own data is a search running on hope alone. You have better tools than that.

Practical advice. At the end of every week, go through your list of active opportunities and rank them in order of maturity. Be brutally honest. Strike out the ones that should be qualified out based on either negative feedback or a lack of any feedback over a sustained period. Keep the list clean at all times.

At times, the small number of remaining opportunities will cause concern. Over time, however, you will thank yourself for being able to trust this data source. A clean list of five real conversations is worth more than a bloated list of twenty that are going nowhere. Discipline here protects your energy and your perception of where the search actually stands

> *"A short honest list beats a long comfortable one. Every time."*

The ranking criteria are deliberately simple: how likely is this to convert, and how quickly? Those two dimensions capture almost everything that matters at any given point in the search. The contact seniority column is particularly telling — as the examples below illustrate, the person you are speaking with at a company is often a stronger predictor of outcome than the company itself.

BRUTALLY HONEST RANKING (*) IN TERMS OF PROBABILITY AND SPEED TO CONVERT INTO A JOB

Company	Contact order	Date contacted	Ranking (*)	Contact seniority	Role type / seniority	Vertical	Company size	Solution domain	Geography
Company1	1	—	6	Junior / connector					
Company2	2	—	7	Very junior / information					
Company3	3	—	3	Very senior / above hiring manager					
Company4	4	—	1	Very senior / hiring manager					
Company5	5	—	4	HR / Internal TA					
Company6	6	—	2	HR / Internal TA					
Company7	7	—	3	HR / Internal TA					
(*) Ranking: 1 = highest probability / fastest to close	1–2 Active / high priority	3–4 Possible / developing	5+ Cold / low probability						

Use this template as your weekly review tool. Update the ranking every Friday. Anything ranked 5 or above that has seen no movement in three weeks should be honestly considered for removal from the active list. The goal is not to be pessimistic — it is to free your attention and energy for the conversations that are genuinely moving.

On the difficult days — and there will be difficult days, days when nothing seems to be moving and the silence feels total — open the journal. Read it from the beginning. You will almost always find that more has happened than you remembered. A contact made in week two that you have mentally written off. A conversation in week five that planted a seed you have not yet watered. A signal from a company you had almost struck from your list. The journal makes the invisible visible, and the visible manageable. It is never nothing.

Use those review sessions actively. Look for patterns. Which conversations have stalled at the same stage? Which contacts have gone quiet after showing early interest? Which companies have

signalled interest without you having approached them directly? The notes will suggest follow-up actions and new connections you would not have thought of without them. They are not just a record — they are a thinking tool.

One more thing: in your conversations, resist the urge to pin people down to a specific next date. A natural human impulse is to end every call with: shall we speak again on Thursday the fourteenth? But this creates false pressure for both parties, and when the date passes without contact, the silence feels loaded. Instead, express genuine curiosity about what the other person is navigating — professionally, even personally. When you understand their context, radio silence finds its own explanation. They are travelling. They are in board season. They have a restructuring underway. It is not lack of interest. It is simply process — and now you know enough to read it that way.

> *"The journal will remind you, on the worst days, that more has happened than you think. It is never nothing."*

DO

- Follow up once, with something of value to add
- Keep the pipeline full — silence from one opportunity hurts less
- Use quiet periods for refinement: pitch, list, research
- Maintain your physical routine and mental equilibrium
- Remember: silence is process, not judgment

DON'T

- Follow up more than once in two weeks on the same thread
- Widen your search indiscriminately when things go quiet
- Say yes to conversations you should decline
- Signal availability when you should signal selectivity
- Let a single stalled opportunity consume your emotional energy

REFLECTION

When silence hits, what is your instinct? Write it down — then ask yourself whether acting on that instinct would help or hurt your candidacy.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Stage 4 — One or more companies have chosen you. Now what?

Being the preferred candidate is not the finish line. It is the moment most people mishandle.

At some point — if you have executed Stages 1, 2, and 3 well — one or more companies will identify you as their preferred candidate. This is the moment the search has been building toward. It is also, paradoxically, one of the moments in which the most errors are made.

The errors come in two directions: either the candidate becomes too passive, assuming the deal is done and relaxing into the process, or they become too aggressive, pressing hard on terms before the relationship is fully secured. Both approaches can cost you the offer. What is needed instead is a specific kind of active patience — engaged, confident, and disciplined.

> *"Being their top choice means they want you. It does not mean you have the job. Keep going."*

Managing the advantage without overplaying it

The preferred candidate position gives you leverage — but leverage only holds if the other party believes you have alternatives. If you have been running a proper pipeline search, this should be true. If you have only one active process and the company knows it, your leverage is limited. This is one of the most important reasons to maintain multiple conversations simultaneously throughout the search.

In practice, managing this moment means: continuing to be genuinely engaged and responsive, continuing to do the research and preparation that signals you are serious, and — if you have other live processes — being transparent that you are in conversation elsewhere without being specific or aggressive about it. ‘I am in discussions with a couple of other organisations and I would like to be respectful of everyone's time’ is a legitimate and useful thing to say. ‘I have an offer on the table from Company X and I need your answer by Thursday’ often is not, unless it is true.

How to negotiate from a position of strength

Negotiation at this stage is most effective when it is framed as a conversation about fit rather than a battle over terms. You are trying to understand whether the role, the package, and the organisation genuinely work for you — and to ensure that your counterpart understands what it will take to bring you in. That is a different posture from I want more money.

Know your number before the conversation. Know what elements of the package matter most to you — base salary, bonus structure, equity, title, reporting line, flexibility — and rank them. Not everything can be negotiated, and some things matter to you more than others. Going in with clarity about your priorities allows you to negotiate on what matters without dying on every hill.

Respond to an offer within a reasonable timeframe. Asking for a week is normal. Asking for three weeks signals indecision. If you need time because of another live process, say so honestly: 'I am very excited about this opportunity and I want to be straightforward with you — I am in a late-stage process elsewhere and I want to give you a clear answer rather than a provisional one'. Most organisations respect honesty far more than they respect games.

ACTIVE PATIENCE	TRANSPARENT LEVERAGE	RANKED PRIORITIES
Stay engaged, keep preparing, keep showing up. The deal is not done until it is signed.	If you have other processes, say so honestly — without names or artificial deadlines.	Know what you want most before you negotiate. Not everything is equally important.

Finally: when the offer comes and the terms are right, accept it clearly and enthusiastically. The moment of acceptance is the foundation of the new professional relationship. How you handle it — with grace, with clarity, with genuine warmth — sets the tone for everything that follows.

DO

- Keep your pipeline running until a contract is signed
- Be transparent about other processes without being aggressive
- Know your priorities before the negotiation conversation begins
- Respond to offers promptly and decisively
- Accept clearly and enthusiastically when the terms are right

DON'T

- Assume the deal is done before it is signed
- Invent competing offers you do not have
- Negotiate every term with equal intensity
- Delay responding without a clear and honest reason
- Let the negotiation damage the relationship you have built

REFLECTION

If you received an offer tomorrow, do you know what you would accept and what you would push back on? Write the list now, before the pressure of the moment makes it harder to think clearly.

PART THREE

The complete do's and don'ts

A rapid-reference summary of the most important behaviours across all four stages. Return to this section at the start of each new stage.

The complete do's and don'ts

This section is designed to be re-read, not just read once. At the start of each stage of your search, come back here. Check your behaviours against the list. Ask yourself honestly which column you have been living in.

> *"The difference between a search that takes four months and one that takes eight is almost always in these lists — not in the market, and not in your CV."*

Stage 1 — Reflection, research and clarity

DO

- Define your value proposition in two sentences before anything else
- Identify solution domain, company size, role, vertical, and geography specifically — not as a range
- Build a named list of 30-50 target companies
- Research the specific hiring managers by name
- Have both a 30-second and a 5-minute pitch ready
- Rehearse out loud, on camera, with real feedback

DON'T

- Start outreach before your clarity work is done
- Describe yourself in generic terms: senior leader, change agent
- Send the same pitch to every contact
- Assume headhunters will do your outreach for you
- Skip rehearsal because you are confident in conversation

Stage 2 — Outbound search: the five groups

DO

- Map every contact to one of the five groups before reaching out
- Be specific: name the person you want to meet, not the type
- Approach Groups 3 and 4 as a peer with prepared relevance
- Track every conversation with a next step and follow-up date
- Use Groups 1 and 2 to sharpen your pitch before Group 3

DON'T

- Treat your network as one undifferentiated resource
- Ask for vague help without a clear, specific ask
- Open a potential-employer conversation with the job ask
- Neglect Groups 3 and 4 in favour of comfort conversations
- Let introductions die without following through promptly

Stage 3 — Radio silence

DO

- Follow up once, after a reasonable interval, with value to add
- Keep five or more conversations active so no single one dominates
- Use quiet periods to refine your pitch and research
- Maintain your physical routine and daily structure
- Remember: silence is process, not judgment

DON'T

- Follow up repeatedly on the same thread in a short window
- Widen your search indiscriminately when things slow down
- Accept every exploratory conversation out of anxiety
- Signal availability when you should signal selectivity
- Let one stalled opportunity destabilise your whole search

Stage 4 — Managing the preferred candidate moment

DO

- Keep your pipeline running until a contract is signed
- Be honest about other processes — without names or ultimatums
- Know your negotiation priorities before the conversation
- Respond to offers promptly and with genuine enthusiasm
- Accept clearly and warmly when the terms are right

DON'T

- Assume the offer is secure before it is in writing
- Invent competing offers or artificial deadlines
- Negotiate every term with equal aggression
- Take longer than a week to respond without honest explanation
- Let the negotiation damage the relationship you are building

A final word

You will get through this. Not because everything will go smoothly — it will not. Not because you will not have bad days — you will. But because you are more experienced, more resilient, and more capable than this moment feels right now.

The search is not a reflection of your worth. It is a process with its own rhythm, its own pace, and its own logic. Your job is to run it well, to protect your candidacy at every stage, and to trust — based on evidence, not optimism — that the right opportunity is on its way.

The product is you. You know it better than anything you have ever sold. Go close the deal. And if you are new to sales, this is your chance to add a powerful new arrow to your quiver.

Even if you came across this book weeks or months after losing your job, I hope you will find something useful and helpful to give new impulse to your journey back to employment.

> *"Whoever deserves you will find you. Do the work to make sure they can."*